mainland to the island of Lanka in the golden age of the Treta Yuga; or that the Buddha Sakyamuni ascended to the Tushita heaven on a ladder to preach to the mothers of all the Buddhas; or that the Prophets Elijah and Moses appeared before Jesus of Nazareth on a high mountain; or that the Prophet Muhammad rode Al-Buraq, the winged steed, on his night ride from Mecca to Jerusalem; or that when the Guru Nanak visited Mecca the Kaaba moved to be wherever his feet pointed – then please read no further. This is not the book for you and I have no wish to cause you offence.

And you, reader, since your eyes are still on this page – thank you for keeping an open mind.

Charles Allen, London